Signal Without Strategy v1.1 — reviewer cover memo

Date: 2026-08-27 · **Status:** draft for co-author review. Not submitted.

What the paper claims

Search attention is associated with unusually active earnings events in retrospective matched comparisons, but it does not provide reliable incremental forecasting or trading value.

Every qualifier carries weight. *Retrospective*: nothing was preregistered. *Matched*: the comparison is against comparable earnings events, not ordinary weeks. *Association*: every incremental test was null.

The five things a reviewer should check first

1. Retrospective matched association — the one positive result. Corrected matched-pair analysis: **+2.0797 pp**, **p = 0.00397**, 73 pairs, CR2 clustered on ticker. Stable across leave-one-ticker-out refits (**+1.8343 to +2.3772 pp**). This is a **Level-1 association only** — not prediction, not causation, not tradability. It was estimated on data already observed.

A **separate** ticker-clustered regression over the full event population gives **+1.509 pp**, **p = 0.0662**, 95% CI **[–0.113, +3.131]** — suggestive, spanning zero, not supported at 5%. These are different specifications on different samples with different estimands, **not competing versions of one number**.

2. Null incremental prediction. Against a strong price-and-calendar baseline the marginal contribution of attention was **+0.0131 pp**, **p = 0.98332**. Out-of-sample magnitude error was **3.6299** with attention versus **3.6284** without (paired **p = 0.9827**) — marginally *worse*. A logistic direction model was worse calibrated than assuming the base rate (Brier **0.2711** vs **0.2560**; AUC **0.4654**, below chance).

3. Null GST-specific tradability. A standalone event strategy returned a mean net **0.8543%** per event. **The same post-earnings drift was present without the attention filter.** That return is a property of the earnings-event population the filter selected into, not an attention result, and it must not be cited as one.

4. A design-versus-result discrepancy we did not smooth over. The frozen corrective design specifies leave-one-ticker-out over **28** refits. The committed results report **26** refits and 26 per-ticker entries. We report the realised **26** and flag the difference. Nothing was recomputed to reconcile it.

5. Imperfect match balance. Treated events carry mean |pre-drift| of **3.619 pp** against **2.9662 pp** for controls. Some of the measured difference may reflect pre-event activity the match did not remove. Disclosed in §5.1 and §11 as a limitation of the match, not a result.

The prospective study

A separate preregistered protocol (internally "HYP-01") is designed to test whether the Level-1 association survives prospectively. **It has produced no results of any kind**: zero of the required 60 eligible events collected, no outcome analysed, and open methodological decisions in its own governing record — including no registered smallest-effect-size-of-interest. It contributes **no evidence** to this manuscript, and nothing here anticipates its outcome.

What we did not do

No analysis was rerun. No specification was searched. No confidence interval was computed to fill a gap — fields absent from the committed artifacts are marked "not in artifact" and left blank. No external coefficient is used as an effect-size anchor; a bounded literature search closed on 2026-08-26 without finding a comparable published estimate.

Verification available to a reviewer

Every numerical claim resolves to a committed artifact with an exact JSON pointer or CSV field, full-precision source value, rounding rule, and status (`CURRENT` / `SENSITIVITY` / `SUPERSEDED` / `HISTORICAL_CONTEXT`). The number-audit supplement in this package lists all 65. Two automated checkers run against the manuscript: the original v1.0 checker (82 claims) and an extended v1.1 checker (154 claims, 213 distinct numeric tokens accounted for) that additionally refuses causal, alpha and confirmatory language, refuses promotion of a secondary result over a designated primary, and verifies that superseded and non-comparable historical results stay labelled as such.

Package contents

File	What it is
`Signal_Without_Strategy_v1.1_MANUSCRIPT.pdf`	The manuscript
`Signal_Without_Strategy_v1.1_FIGURES.pdf`	Figures 1–3 with captions
`Signal_Without_Strategy_v1.1_NUMBER_AUDIT.pdf`	65 claims, each traced to source
`Signal_Without_Strategy_v1.1_FIGURE_TABLE_PLAN.pdf`	Display specification
`Signal_Without_Strategy_v1.1_COVER_MEMO.pdf`	This memo
`tables/*.csv`	Every manuscript table, cell text verbatim

No prospective panel data, no financial or search values, and no HYP-01 outcome are included in this package.